

After Authenticity: The Irreducible Human Remainder

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The preceding analysis examined how material conditions, scarcity, and friction have historically stabilised meaning in symbolic media. This follow-up proceeds from the same framework, but asks a further question: what remains once even those material and technical stabilisers are assumed to be ultimately defeatable under sufficiently advanced artificial intelligence?

1. The Failure of Technical Guarantees

No technical system can permanently guarantee what is real in the presence of sufficiently advanced AI. Any rule for authenticity can be learned, reproduced, and ultimately defeated. This applies to provenance systems, material analysis, custody chains, and institutional verification. The failure is structural rather than a result of poor engineering. Authenticity was mistakenly treated as an engineering problem when it was always a temporal one; systems can check consistency, but they cannot enforce historical singularity once perfect replication is possible. At the point of total generativity, “verification” only distinguishes compliance with a model, not originals from reconstructions.

2. The Quiet Shift in the Meaning of “Correct”

Correctness changes meaning once AI systems are trusted as final arbiters. There are two kinds of correctness: correspondence to what happened, and satisfaction of the system. AI inevitably optimises for the latter. When correctness becomes procedural rather than experiential, human judgment is reclassified as noise, and doubt or memory unreliability are viewed as inefficiencies or failures. Eventually, the question of whether something is “real” is replaced by whether it “passes”.

3. Authenticity Was Never in the Object

Authenticity has never resided in material artifacts themselves. Even before AI, objects degraded and records were incomplete, yet meaning persisted because humans continued to hold certain things as real and significant. Artifacts functioned as anchors that slowed forgetting and focused care, but they did not store authenticity like data stores bits. The mistake was assuming material fidelity would make authenticity self-sustaining; AI exposes that this was never true.

4. The Human Act That Cannot Be Automated

There is one act AI cannot perform: holding something as real on behalf of other humans. A human situates an object in lived relationships, accepts responsibility for its meaning, and risks reputation by standing behind it. An AI can describe these things, but it cannot enter them. This commitment under uncertainty cannot be verified without destroying it; the moment it becomes procedural, it ceases to be what it is.

5. When AI Becomes the Authority

Once AI is the authority of correctness, humans move from judging to complying, remembering to retrieving, and holding to accepting. History becomes replayable but not remembered. Meaning is produced through validation rather than care and continuity. The past survives as representation, but not as obligation—resulting in a loss of responsibility for truth.

6. Why Everything Else Is Ultimately Defeatable

Any safeguard added simply restarts the cycle: better provenance leads to better forgery, and deeper context leads to deeper simulation. There is no final layer. The error is searching for an undefeatable system when authenticity was always something that had to be renewed; systems only existed to buy time for that renewal to occur.

7. What Actually Remains

What survives is not proof, but choice. Humans decide which continuities to honour and which objects remain charged with meaning, doing so without certainty. This choice is costly, taking time and risking error, which is precisely why it matters. AI removes cost, but meaning follows cost.

8. The Final Position

The preservation of the real is no longer a technical problem; it is an ethical and cultural decision about whether humans remain the place where meaning is decided. If judgment is ceded to systems, authenticity becomes unnecessary. The world continues to function, but history becomes simulation rather than inheritance.

9. Final Reassurance

Read alongside *The Materiality of the Symbol*, this piece finishes the argument by removing the last technical comfort and asking whether humans are still willing to carry meaning once certainty is gone.